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The Descartes-Huygens correspondence

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SOMMAIRE. — La correspondance entre Descartes et Huygens, quoique maintenant absorbée dans le corpus général des lettres de Descartes, garde son intérêt et son importance propre. A part son caractère unique, comme série complète de lettres échangées entre deux hommes d'une distinction si différente, elle nous montre avec quelle précaution il nous faut accepter le texte des lettres de Clerselier et le récit de Baillet sur la vie de Descartes en Hollande. Et comme toutes les vies de Descartes reposent finalement sur Clerselier et Baillet, notre Correspondance nous montre qu'il est nécessaire d'examiner à nouveau tout le problème.

It would seem perhaps a paradox that, at the request of the Organising Committee, I should allow myself to discuss the value of the Descartes-Huygens Correspondence now, since this Correspondence, till now available only in the *editio princeps* published with all due honor by the Oxford Press, is now being absorbed into the general corpus of Descartes' letters by the new and complete edition in course of publication. But for myself I am glad of the opportunity to express my admiration of the new edition with its finality of scholarship and sureness of execution, and in particular to offer my congratulations to M. Ch. Adam, the representative of the great French tradition of humane letters to whom all lovers of philosophy and of Descartes are so deeply in debt, on the completion of the work begun so fruitfully over forty years ago.

§ 1.

The Descartes-Huygens Correspondence, treated as a separate entity, is unique in three respects. It is almost wholly manuscript ; it is almost completely self-contained ; and it is the product of a sincere affection between two men of genius whose distinction was in different fields. The last point is perhaps unexpected since it might be thought that the most valuable part of a philosopher's correspondence would be that with other philosophers ; and this is of course true from the point of view of technical philosophy. But I am inclined to plead that a man's philosophy is not a special piece of expert knowledge produced in a laboratory and developed in a " school " but the product of his total reaction to life, and in that case the mutual friendship of a philosopher and a statesman is of greater significance, maybe, than a professional connexion between one philosopher and another. Constantijn Huygens was a man of extraordinary gifts highly developed, and his admiration for Descartes, as that of Descartes for him, was unfeigned. There is a freshness therefore in their intercourse which is ultimately more revealing than the guarded and diplomatic attitude assumed perforce by Descartes towards others. In addition therefore to the more specialist points of (a) textual and (b) historical criticism raised by this particular Correspondence, its interest is also (c) personal and psychological.

§ 2 (a).

The new edition of the letters of Descartes prints them with modern spelling and in accordance with modern ideas of punctuation. I congratulate the editors on their courage and have no quarrel with their results ; indeed I think theirs the wiser path. Descartes himself recognised, and drew attention to, the carelessness and vagaries of his writing, and the problems to which it gives rise are incapable — *experto credite* — of a consistent editorial solution. At the same time, as in all cases of a " modernised " text, it is well worth the student's while to refer back as far as he can to the earliest available sources.

The reason for this is not only a sentimental one, though the sense of personal contact with an author, which is only derivable from the use of the manuscript or contemporary editions, is well worth the effort to achieve. It is that the Descartes who has passed into his-

tory is a Descartes who was "manipulated" by his first editor. A thorough understanding of the *real* Descartes is possible only if we have before us the very words that Descartes wrote. But in addition to the *real* Descartes there is the Descartes of *Clerselier*, the Descartes whose image is imprinted on the fundamental life of Baillet and hence on all subsequent lives, and *this* Descartes, the Descartes of "history", is only understandable if we are given not what Descartes wrote himself but what *Clerselier* printed in his name. M. Adam's first edition offered a collation between the original manuscript and *Clerselier's* text in those cases in which the original manuscript survived, but the material provided was so scattered as not to arouse special attention. It is one of the great merits of the Descartes-Huygens correspondence that it raised the issue in an inescapable form.

As an example of the differences which emerged from M. Adam's collation in his first edition the following may be taken. Descartes, writing to Mersenne on 8 october 1629, is proposing the publication of the book to appear finally in 1637 as the *Météores*. We know that the *Météores*, and the *Discours* which accompanied it and the other *Essais*, were published in French, and we look upon this publication in *French* as one of the landmarks in the emancipation of modern thought from the medievalism imposed by scholastic Latin. How and when the happy thought occurred to Descartes to write in French we do not know exactly. But it certainly was not his in 1629 when he writes specifically (Corresp. 1, 24, 1.3 ; ed. 2, p. 49) that the treatise is to be in *Latin* ("ie tascheray de l'expliquer en sorte que tous ceux qui, seulement, entendront le latin puissent prendre plaisir à le lire"). *Clerselier* however, publishing the letter in 1659, twenty-two years after the publication of the *Météores* in *French*, prints not *le latin* but *le françois*, thus adapting the text to the historical fact but in so doing he conceals another fact no less historical and of still greater interest.

This point is, I agree, trivial and I doubt whether even a close reader would have paid much attention either to this or to the numerous other examples to be gleaned from M. Adam's critical notes. But the canvas offered by the Descartes-Huygens Correspondence is much smaller, and since its contents were almost entirely unedited, special attention was naturally directed to such of the letters as had been seen and published by *Clerselier*. One example, the importance of which was noted by M. Adam himself in the preface with which he adorned the edition of this Correspondence, is that of the letter of

consolation written by Descartes to Huygens on the occasion of the death of Mrs Huygens. This letter was printed by Clerselier (the obvious assumption is that it was copied from the original and circulated, although of course Descartes' own minute may well have survived among his papers), but between Descartes' own text and the text printed by Clerselier there is all the difference between a mildly agnostic view of immortality and the strict belief of theological dogmatism. I am not suggesting of course that Descartes was not a religious man, or that he was not a sincere upholder of the tenets of the Catholic faith. On the contrary I think that all the real evidence goes to show that he was. But I am troubled by the fact that much of the "evidence" often adduced in support of this thesis is derived, either immediately or ultimately, from Clerselier's text of Descartes' correspondence. For example, in M. Maritain's volume *Le Songe de Descartes* this very passage is referred to (p. 314) as the "texte bien connu" to which some remarks of the distinguished author are said to be able "servir de commentaire", and considerable learning is afterwards displayed in order to settle the problem whether Descartes' phrases, (that is, the phrases printed as Descartes' by Clerselier) were or were not reminiscent of certain passages of St. Thomas. The curious will find in this example much matter for reflection. But in any case it seems to me that it would be well worth while, in the light of this hint supplied by the study of our correspondence, to "check up" every reference to questions of religion contained in Descartes' letters and to accept as authoritative nothing which is not certified by Descartes' own hand.

The suggestion may be drastic, but the suspicion on which it is founded is not voiced here for the first time. Baillet remarks in his preface on the "differences between" such letters as he and his friends could trace in manuscript and "those printed" by Clerselier (pref. xxxiv), and in at least two places in the life he comments adversely on the unreliability of Clerselier's general editing (vol. II, p. 10, note; p. 402, note). He adds that Clerselier modified some of Descartes' phrases ("ôté quelques termes d'aigreur") in order to "suit Descartes' intentions", and it may be that this statement is meant to cover a deliberate modification of Descartes' remarks on subjects of religion. One may add that such a charge would not be out of the way as it is made specifically by Father Daniel in his *Voyage du Monde* (ed. 2, 1702, p. 131) with regard to certain passages in the French translation of Descartes' *Principia*.

sin in the second volume of his *Fragments philosophiques* (ed. 3, Paris, 1838, p. 155 ff.). Huyghens points out the inaccuracies of all Baillet's references both to himself and his family, and to the Academies in Holland and their learned men. The inaccuracies are certainly in some cases inexcusable ; but the interesting thing is that they should appear at all. They show that Baillet, for all his evident care and scrupulousness in his search for the truth, could not get his facts right even with regard to so celebrated man as Christiaan Huyghens (a man of world-wide reputation who had lived for twenty years in Paris itself) because of an ignorance of Holland and its worthies which would seem complete ; and it is this gap in his knowledge, that is, in *our* knowledge, which is now bridged, at least in part, by the Descartes-Huygens Correspondence.

§ 4 (c).

Our Correspondence is thus all-important for the criticism of the sources of our conceptions of Descartes. In spite of all the happy discoveries of recent years those conceptions derive ultimately from Clerselier and Baillet ; but Clerselier's ideas of the functions of an editor render all deductions from his text unreliable and Baillet has no independent knowledge of Descartes' life in Holland. It follows that the whole question needs a fundamental re-examination. M. Adam himself commented quite rightly on the sequence of the early lives of Descartes (*Vie*, préface), and his own great *Life* has passed into a similar sequence (Gilson, *Rôle de la Pensée médiévale*, Vrin, 1930, p. 282). It is doubtful however whether even yet, in spite of the labors of so many distinguished students, the preliminary conditions he himself indicated as necessary for the final life, have been fulfilled, and we have had to wait till these last years even for the undertaking of some of the most fundamental among them, including M. de Waard's edition of the letters of Mersenne and M. Adam's own revised edition of those of Descartes. Until this last is completed the Descartes-Huygens Correspondence will remain indispensable, and it may retain, indeed, some importance even after that, and for the following reason.

It is obvious that letters lose by being dispersed ; correspondence to have significance must be united. On the other hand an editor can only print the letters of all the various correspondents in one and the same chronological sequence. It follows that the more complete

and comprehensive an edition is, the more it destroys the links between each separate correspondence. And the matter is complicated further if we remember that a correspondence, to have real significance, must comprise both sides. In the case of Descartes we have for the most part one side only, that of Descartes himself, and we can only guess what he is replying to, and sometimes even whom he is replying to, by inference.

To this the Descartes-Huygens correspondence is an exception. By a lucky accident, which we can trace, we have both sides together. We know exactly what Descartes and Huygens wrote and what Descartes and Huygens replied. We can thus follow Descartes' interests and pre-occupations for the course of twelve whole years, and when we remember that these twelve years were those in which he published his thoughts to the world the significance of this Correspondence cannot be exaggerated.

There is here no space to go into the innumerable personal details revealed by the correspondence as a whole, nor the references, sometimes lengthy, to contemporary scholars, men of letters, and other eminent persons. We see the "inside" of famous literary quarrels (e. g. that between Huygens and Saumaise), and, for the first time, the long and full story of the embittered dispute between Descartes and the mathematician Stampioen to which a learned Belgian, M. H. Bosmans, S. J., has since devoted a special monograph. We have fresh details of the persecutions suffered by Descartes at the hands of the theologians arising from precisely those sorts of disputes which, ironically enough, he had fled Paris to avoid. We have a long letter on musical theory which recalls Descartes' first complete treatise, the *Traité de la Musique* associated with Beeckman. We have sidelights on Heinsius, Balzac, Saumaise and a score of others who had found a home in the Netherlands. But no one of these details has the interest of the Correspondence as one whole in which we see Descartes passing from one interest, literary or personal, to another while the course of his life flows by.

M. Adam in his preface to the printed edition has called attention to some of the "stories" of the correspondence — Descartes' scepticism when told of the girl in Brittany whose body marked the calendar of the saints' days; his intervention on behalf of a poor neighbour accused of manslaughter; his efforts to find Gillot a place (I still hope that he is the "Mons. Chilot, Portugalliæ Regis mathematicus" of Lipstorp); his love for hunting and his friendly relations with the

Huygens ladies. Among these episodes is one which is of peculiar interest to us today as we celebrate the centenary of the publication of the *Discours de la Méthode*. It is the episode of the "privilege", the granting of which by the "King in Council" was necessary in order to protect Descartes and his publisher against unauthorised printings of the book. From the very first mention of the "preface" to the combined *Dioptrique* and *Météores* to the day when the first copy of the completed book containing the *Discours de la Méthode* and the *Essais* was presented, as was fitting, to the Prince of Orange, we can follow the volume month by month, often week by week, at times day by day. It was through Huygens that the sheets were sent to Mersenne in Paris, and it was through Huygens that news of the progress of the affair was sent back to Descartes; it was through Huygens too that the precious letter of Mersenne explaining the causes of the delay in procuring the privilege was sent to Descartes, to be sent by Descartes to Huygens and hence to be preserved for posterity. And it was Huygens who was the first to read, so far as we have record, the printed sheets he was transmitting of the *Discours de la Méthode*. This tercentenary meeting in honor of a book which its own author said he thought would never reach a second edition could add little to what Huygens then said, and I close these notes with the quotation: "en passant j'ay deuoré vostre discours de la Methode, qui veritablement est la piece la mieux digerée, la plus meure, et, comme il me semble que les Italiens s'en expliquent viuement, la *più saporita*, que j'aye jamais veuë. S'il importe que vous en sachiez mon opinion, je proteste qu'elle me satisfaict en toute extremité."
